

The Cold Call Playbook

What still works on the phone in 2026, from someone who still dials.

Built from 25 years selling, plus 2026 benchmark data on 200,000+ calls. Every number here is sourced at the bottom.

THE ONE RULE

You get one clean introduction to any account. Spend it on the person who can actually sign.

Your first ten seconds

Say this	"How have you been?" Openers using it book at up to 6.6x the rate. It sounds like a person, not a script.
Never this	"Did I catch you at a bad time?" drops booking rates roughly 40% . You are handing them the exit in your first sentence.
Then	Name the reason you called <i>this</i> person, not this list. One specific detail is the whole difference.

When to dial

- **Wednesday** beats Monday and Tuesday by about **50%** for first conversations.
- **11am to 12pm** and **4pm to 5pm** in their time zone.
- Late afternoon outperforms morning by **71%**.
- Block it. A dialing hour you protect beats three you intend.

Who you dial

- Verified mobile direct dials roughly **double** connect rates versus switchboard numbers.
- Scraped lists connect at only **5 to 8%**.
- **94%** of people now assume an unknown number is spam. Your caller ID is part of the pitch.
- Confirm the decision maker still holds the role *before* you dial.

The math nobody tells rookies

- **93%** of leads that convert are reached on the **sixth call or later**. Most reps stop at two.
- Pairing calls with email and LinkedIn lifts conversion about **28%** over calling alone.
- Top performers talk **43%** of the time and listen **57%**. If you are talking more than half, you are losing it.
- Industry average success sits near **2.7%**. That is normal. It is not a verdict on you.

What is actually dead

- Dialing a bought list with no context. That is not cold calling, that is noise.
- Pressure, false urgency, and manufactured scarcity. **96%** of buyers research you first and resent being rushed.
- Going around the gatekeeper. She is not the obstacle, she is the best-informed person who will still take your call.

Sources: Cognism State of Cold Calling 2026 (200k+ calls) • Gong opener research • SkipCall 2026 connect-rate benchmarks • ZoomInfo • Prospeo, high-pressure selling 2026. Figures vary by industry and data quality; treat them as direction, not promises.